

K'idinc'ey/k'idinc'iy (lesson eight)

Areal w(i)- ~ ho-

Another fairly common prefix is the “areal” prefix, **w(i)-** or **ho-**. This can be a possessive prefix, object of postposition prefix, or direct object prefix. It is required with nouns that belong to the “areal” class. Here are some common areal nouns:

yikh ‘house’	keyikh ‘village’
-t'ak ‘back (of body)’	-tl'it ‘low back, waist’
-kak ‘surface’, yin kak ‘world’	yin tah ‘territory’
-t'ayik ‘chest, front side’	-k'ëts'ikh ‘armpit’

When one of these areal nouns is the possessor, the possessed object must be prefixed with some form of the areal prefix. Compare the following:

bidis k'iz	‘one of his/her lungs’
yikh wik 'iz	‘half a house’ (lit. ‘the house its half’)
silhtsen bic'e'	‘my brother’s belongings’
yikh wic 'e'	‘home furnishings’ (lit. ‘the house’s belongings’)
lhok bizkiy'	‘the fish’s blood’
st'ak wizkiy '	‘blood from my back’ (lit. ‘my back’s blood’)
sdiñ' (bighiyecldic)	‘I’m talking about my man’
yin kak widini '	‘human being’ (lit. ‘world’s person’)

When the possessive prefix is added to a noun that starts with **u**, that **u** must become **o**, even though **w** is not one of the consonants that triggers a change of **u** to **o**. (This is because this form of the Witsuwit'en prefix used to be pronounced **wh-** (it is still pronounced that way in Babine.)

buzi'	‘his/her name’
yin tah wozi '	‘place name’ (lit. ‘territory’s name’)

w(i)- also must be added to a postposition when an areal noun is the object of the postposition. Compare the following:

sbe 'iyinlegh	‘he/she made it for me’
yikh wibe 'iyinlegh	‘he/she made it for the house’

yilh yelhdic
keyikh wilh yelhdic

'he/she is talking to him/her/it'
'he/she is talking to the village (buildings)'

The verbal areal prefix is a little different in shape from the noun and postposition prefixes. When an areal noun is the subject of an intransitive verb (a verb that cannot take an object), the verb must be prefixed with **w(i)-**. Compare the following examples.

bizkak hiley
many')
yikh wiley

'he/she has many children' (lit. 'his/her children are many')
'there are many houses'

dzut dighe(')
bit'ayik widighe(')

'fur coat' (lit. 'coat which is hairy, furry')
'his chest is hairy'

c'ilhtiy tēzkēz
stl'it witēzkēz

'a/the gun fired'
'my low back went out' (lit. 'my low back fired')

If the verb is transitive (meaning it must occur with an object), and the object is an areal noun, then the verb must be prefixed with **w-**:

lhic yit'iy
yikh wit'iy

'he/she has/owns the dog'
'he/she owns a/the house'

(wit'en of Witsuwit'en is in fact formed from wit'iy.)

In addition to **wi-**, which we see in the preceding examples, the verbal areal prefix has a form **ho-** when it is followed by a vowel other than **i**, such as **in-** 'you (sg.)'. Compare the following:

ilhcot
yikh holhcot (< ho-ilhcot)

'take it'
'take the house'

sincis sbe ints'it
st'ak sbe honts'it

'scratch my nose for me'
'scratch my back for me'

(Notice that the vowel that triggers the **ho-** form of the areal prefix is then deleted.)

Writing practice

The remainder of the imperfective paradigm for 'own house' will be dictated to you, followed by the optative paradigm. Write what you hear:

_____	'I own a house'
_____	'we (du.) own a house'
_____	'we own a house'

_____	‘you own a house’
_____	‘you (pl.) own a house’
_____	‘they own a house’
_____	‘let me own a house’
_____	‘let’s (du.) own a house’
_____	‘let’s own a house’
_____	‘you could own a house’
_____	‘you (pl.) could own a house’
_____	‘let him own a house’
_____	‘let them own a house’

Ways of forming the perfective (past tense)

There are three main ways of forming the past tense in Witsuwit'en, called perfective in Dene linguistics: the s-perfective, the e-perfective, and the n-perfective. Verbs generally have select only one of these ways of forming the perfective. The remainder of this lesson will focus on how to spell the various forms of the s-perfective.

S-perfective

One way of forming the perfective in Witsuwit'en is to add an **s-** or a **z-** in roughly the same position where imperfective **i-**, progressive **ĩ/ě-** and future **ta-** go. We actually saw some examples of s-perfectives in Dik'alt'iy (lesson seven), repeated here with the characteristic s or z- of the s-perfective is in red:

hibegh u zye	'he walked past them'
hibegh u zisyē	'I walked past them'
hibegh u zĩnye	'you walked past them'
hibegh u sdiťaz	'we (du.) walked past them'
hibegh u ziwh'az	'you (du.) walked past them'
hibegh ts'ozdĩl	'we walked past them'
hibegh hoz' z 'az	'they (du.) walked past them'
hibegh hoz' z dĩl	'they walked past them'

Here is another example with the verb 'be'. The present/imperfective actually contains an extra n in the 3sg, 1pl and 3pl but we will not worry about the reason for that right now. The s-perfective involves a slight meaning change ('be' → 'become'). The formula for 'be' is:

—	—	—	lĩ
outer subject	tense	inner subject	root

The root changes from **lĩ** to **li'** in the past tense. The **s** goes in the tense slot, and it changes to **z** in the 1pl and 3pl forms of this verb. These forms could be used after **lhk'u** 'smart', for example. Remember that some speakers insert a d between s and l.

hisli, hisdli	'I am'	s isli', s isdli'	'I became'
ĩnli	'you are'	s enli'	'you became'
nli, hinli	'he/she is'	s ili'	'he/she became'
hididli	'we 2 are'	s didli'	'we 2 became'

ts'enlī	'we are'	ts'izlī', ts'izdlī'	'we became'
hiwhlī	'you pl. are'	siwhlī'	'you pl. became'
henlī	'they are'	hizlī', hizdlī'	'they became'

Here is another example. The verb 'walk, go' is very common, and has some special features. There are three different forms of the verb root for 'walk, go', depending on the number of the subject: -ye singular, 'as dual, -dīlh plural. The formula for the verb, with ni- 'around', is:

ni	_____	_____	_____	ye/'as/dīlh
'around'	outer subject	tense	inner subject	root

We encountered ni 'around', called the continuative prefix in Dene linguistics, earlier. Every motion verb can be prefixed with the continuative prefix. Prefixes which must be added to the left of the outer subjects are traditionally called *disjunct* prefixes in Dene linguistics and in the dictionary they are signalled with #: thus ni# 'around' (continuative).

nisyē	'I'm walking around'	nisisyē	'I walked around'
nīnyē	'you're walking around'	nisenyē	'you walked around'
niyē	'he/she is walking around'	nisiyē	'he/she walked around'
nidit'as	'we 2 walking around'	nisdit'az	'we 2 walked around'
nits'idīlh	'we're walking around'	nits'izdīl	'we walked around'
niwh'as	'you 2 are walking around'	nisiwh'az	'you 2 walked around'
niwhdīlh	'you pl. are walking around'	nisiwhdīl	'you pl. walked around'
naa'as	'they 2 are walking around'	naaz'az	'they 2 walked around'
naadīlh	'they're walking around'	naazdīl	'they walked around'

We can now state something of a rule for when the s-perfective is s or z: use s when word-initial, or after a disjunct prefix. Use z- after an outer subject or a prefix such as **u** which occurs to the left of tense, except always use **s** before **dit-** 1du. subject.

Writing practice

The formula for 'pack O', with continuative prefix, is as follows:

ni	_____	_____	_____	_____	ghï
'around'	direct object	outer subject	tense	inner subject	root

Translate and write the missing forms of the past tense in the spaces provided, using forms of 'walked around' as a model and applying the rule for s and z-. The 3sg has been provided for you; generalize from that.

nisghï	'I'm packing it around'	_____	'I packed it around'
nïnghï	'you're packing it around'	_____	'you packed it around'
niyighï	'he/she is packing it around'	niyizghï	'he/she packed it around'
niditghï	'we 2 are packing it around'	_____	'we 2 packed it around'
nits'ighï	'we're packing it around'	_____	'we packed it around'
niwhghï	'you pl. are packing it around'	_____	'you pl. packed it around'
naayighï	'they're packing it around'	_____	'they packed it around'

S-perfective with l-

The verb 'run' illustrates another common process with the s-perfective. With this verb, there is an l- before the final syllable. The formula for 'run around' is:

ni — — — lggeyh
 continuative outer subject tense inner subject root

This l- combines with the s- in the 3sg, 1pl and 3pl forms (those with no inner subject) to create lh; there is in fact no s or z (on the surface) in those s-perfective forms. Study the following forms. Notice also that ggeyh changes to ggec in the perfective:

nigilggeyh 'I'm running around'	nisigilggec 'I ran around'
nilggeyh 'you're running around'	niselggec 'you ran around'
nilggeyh 'he/she is running around'	nilhggec 'he/she ran around'
nidilggeyh 'we 2 are running around'	nisdilggec 'we 2 ran around'
nits'ilggeyh 'we're running around'	nits'ilhggec 'we ran around'
niwhlhggeyh 'you pl. are running around'	nisiwhlhggec 'you pl. ran around'
naalggeyh 'they're running around'	naalhggec 'they ran around'

Writing practice

The formula for 'chase after, storm after', with continuative prefix, is:

— ilh ni — — — ltsit
 postpositional object postposition continuative outer subject tense inner subject root

This verb is only slightly more complicated than 'run' due to the postposition -ilh and required postpositional object. Given the present tense forms, translate and write the perfective. The 1sg has been provided for you:

bilh nigiltsit 'I'm chasing around after him/her'	bilh nisigiltsit 'I chased around after him/her'
bilh niltsit 'you're chasing after him/her'	_____ 'you chased after him/her'
yilh niltsit 'he/she is chasing after him/her'	_____ 'he/she chased after him/her'

bilh nidiltsit 'we 2 are chasing after him/her'	_____ 'we 2 chased after him/her'
bilh nits'iltsit 'we're chasing after him/her'	_____ 'we chased after him/her'
bilh niwhlhtsit 'you pl. are chasing after him/her'	_____ 'you pl. chased after him/her'
hiyilh niltsit 'they're chasing after him/her'	_____ 'they chased after him/her'

S-perfective with “qualifier” prefixes

Another way of forming the s-perfective occurs when there is a consonantal prefix, such as d-, n-, or t-, between the outer subject and inner subject prefixes. Prefixes which occur in this position are traditionally called “qualifier” prefixes in Dene linguistics. (u- in –egh u- ‘past’ is another qualifier.)

For example, t- can be freely added to motion verbs. The meaning ranges from ‘start’ to ‘leave’. The formula for ‘go’ with t- is:

—	t	—	—	ye/’as/dīlh
outer subject	qualifier	tense	inner subject	root

Study the following forms:

tēzisye	‘I left, started to go’
tēzīnye	‘you...’
tēzye	‘he/she...’
tēsdi’taz	‘we (du.)...’
ts’itēzdīl	‘we...’
tēziwhdīl	‘you (pl.)...’
hitēzdīl	‘they...’

Notice that this t- occurs to the left of the inner subjects but to the right of the outer subjects. All forms also contain a sequence ēz- or ës-, which is the form of the s-perfective used after the consonantal qualifier prefix t-.

When the qualifier is d- or n-, the form of the s- perfective prefix is ïz- or ïs-. (Remember from the first literacy class that ï does not occur after consonants in the class that includes t. That is why ēz- or ës- is used after t-.) Compare the following forms of ‘cut O’, which are both s-perfective. The formula for the verb on the left, ‘cut O once,’ is:

—	—	—	—	t’is
direct object	outer subject	tense	inner subject	root

The forms on the left should look more or less familiar to you by now. In all of the forms on the left, there is no object in the first and second person forms because ‘it’ is null in those persons. ‘it’ is y- with third person forms, and switches places with h- ‘they’. In the forms with no inner

subject prefix (3s, 1p, 3p) (where there is a prefix in direct object or outer subject position), the s-perfective prefix is z-, not s-. The formula for the verb on the right is:

—	—	d	—	—	t'is
direct object	outer subject	qualifier	tense	inner subject	root

The prefix d- is optional when the object being cut is wooden. Notice that the s-perfective prefix is iz- or is- when d- 'wooden' is in qualifier position.

sist'is	'I cut it (once)'	dizist'is	'I cut it once (wood)'
sent'is	'you	dizint'is	
yizt'is	'he/she cut it'	yidizt'is	
sdit'is	'we du....'	disdit'is	
ts'izt'is	'we...'	ts'idizt'is	
siwht'is	'you (pl.)...'	diziwht'is	
hiyizt'is	'they...'	hiydizt'is	

As a final example of the form of the s-perfective when preceded by a qualifier, compare the two verb paradigms below. This is the formula for the verb on the left, 'shoot O once':

—	—	—	—	c'ey/c'iy
direct object	outer subject	tense	inner subject	root

The formula for the verb on the right, 'shoot O by accident', is based on 'shoot O', and contains n- and t-.

—	—	n	—	—	t	c'ey/c'iy
direct object	outer subject	qualifier	tense	inner subject	classifier	root

The part of the verb that means 'by accident' is n...t-, which occur in two positions. (The traditional name of the position where the t- occurs is "classifier". Notice that this t- does not occur in the same position as t- 'start to'.) Because n- precedes the tense position in 'shoot O by accident', the form of the s-perfective prefix that must be used is iz- or is-. There is one more thing to point out about the form of the s-perfective in 'shot it by accident': in the 3sg, 1pl and 3pl, the s-perfective is is- rather than iz-. This is because when the s-perfective directly precedes this t- classifier, it must be pronounced s (similarly to the reason that it is pronounced s in the 1du.).

sisc'ey	'I shot it (once)'	nīzisc'ey	'I shot it by accident'
senc'ey	'you...'	nīzintc'ey	'you...'
yizc'ey	'he/she...'	yiniisc'ey	'he/she...'
sditc'ey	'we (du.)'	nīsditc'ey	'we (du.)'
ts'izc'ey	'we...'	ts'iniisc'ey	'we...'
siwhc'ey	'you (pl.)...'	nīziwhc'ey	'you (pl.)...'
hiyizc'ey	'they...'	hiyniisc'ey	'they...'

Now we are in a position to understand one more verb which forms the past tense with s-. This is the pretty common verb 'kill sg. O'. The formula for this verb is:

—	—	s(z)	—	—	lh	ghī
direct object	outer subject	qualifier	tense	inner subject	classifier	root

Because this verb contains a prefix s- in qualifier position, which is identical or very similar to the īs-/iz- of the s-perfective prefix that is used after a qualifier, the s/z of the perfective prefix is deleted⁵ in 1sg, 2sg, 1du and 2pl forms (but the vowel ī/ē remains):

sēclhghī	'I killed him/her/it' (< s-ēs-c-lhghī)
sēlhghī	'you ...' (< s-ēz-īn-lhghī)
yizīlhghī	'he/she...' (< y-z-īs-lhghī)
sēdilghī	'we (du.)...' (< s-ēs-dit-lhghī)
ts'izīlhghī	'we...' (< ts'-z-īs-lhghī)
sēwhlhghī	'you (pl.)...' (< s-ēs-wh-lhghī)
hiyzīlhghī	'they...' (< h-y-z-īs-lhghī)

Notice that the s in qualifier position of this verb is s when it is word-initial, but z when preceded by a direct object or outer subject prefix (the rule for pronouncing s-qualifier is very similar to s-perfective).

⁵otherwise the first person dual would be sēdilghī, which speakers do not say

Writing practice

Here is our formula again for 'run', with t- 'start to, leaving' added to the formula:

___	t	___	___	l	ggeyh
outer subject	qualifier	tense	inner subject	classifier	root

The 1sg form has been supplied for you. Translate and write the remaining forms:

tëzigilggec	'I started to run, left running'
_____	'you...'
_____	'he/she...'
_____	'we du. ...'
_____	'we ...'
_____	'you (pl.) ...'
_____	'they ...'

One of the forms of 'swallow O' is based on the following formula. This form of 'swallow O' forms the past tense with s-.

___	___	t	___	___	lh	nagh
direct object	outer subject	qualifier	tense	inner subject	classifier	root

The first person singular form of the paradigm has again been supplied for you below. Translate and write the other members of the paradigm:

tëziclhagh	'I swallowed it'
_____	'you ...'
_____	'he/she ...'
_____	'we du. ...'
_____	'we ...'
_____	'you pl. ...'
_____	'they ...'